

Decision Analysis & Ethics

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1. What Decision Analysis does

Decision Analysis begins with an important distinction:

A good decision is not the same thing as a good outcome.

You can make an excellent decision and get unlucky, or a terrible decision and get lucky. DA therefore focuses on the quality of the decision itself. A simplified schematic is:

**Alternatives → Information → Probabilities → Consequences →
Preferences → Choice**

Its question is roughly: *Given what I want, what I know, and what might happen, what should I do?*

DA is demanding about what I believe. Probability judgments can be calibrated and tested against the world. But on the value side, DA mainly requires that my preferences be coherent. Nothing within ordinary DA tells me that a preference itself is morally objectionable.

Even though DA is often described as “amoral”, there may already be ethical assumptions built in, about whose interests count, what responsible deliberation requires, or how people should be treated. Those are important questions, but we won’t address them today.

My concern is narrower: **taking Howard and Korver’s account of applying ethics to Decision Analysis on its own terms, how does it help us decide what we ought to do, and what happens when our ethical principles themselves are uncertain or contested?**

2. Decision Ethics through a case

Ronald Howard and Clinton Korver's 2008 book *Ethics for the Real World* outline what I will be calling **Decision Ethics**. Their account does not treat ethics as another variable to be traded off inside Decision Analysis. Instead, ethical

reflection helps determine which alternatives may properly enter the analysis in the first place.

Let's see how it plays out in practice.

Virginia, 1785

The following is a fictional case situated in a historically real setting. Imagine a Virginia plantation owner in 1785. He thinks of himself as a good man, his neighbors regard him as what they would consider a good master. He inherited the estate, its debts, and its enslaved people. He is a pious Christian, reads moral philosophy, forbids gratuitous cruelty, and provides medical care.

His son has been admitted to Harvard, the fulfillment of a dream he has worked toward for years. The first year's tuition is due in two weeks. The most readily saleable asset is his prized slave, an expert carpenter who is the father of three children on the plantation.

Let's follow through the ethics of the decision.

A. "Amoral" Decision Analysis

He begins with what looks like a financial problem:

How can I pay my son's tuition?

He identifies the alternatives: borrow more money, sell land, cut expenses, sell the man.

If we simply **run the numbers**, selling the man might come out as the best alternative. At this point, DA has not made an ethical judgment at all; it is operating in its **amoral mode**, answering the question it was given.

But Howard and Korver insist that one of the most important tasks in decision-making happens before choosing among alternatives: **getting the frame right**. They warn that "our biggest mistakes in ethical decision making are mistakes in framing" (p. 95).

The signal that something may be missing from the frame is the **inner voice**—a sense of ethical unease that the decision, as posed, does not capture everything that matters.

B. The Inner Voice

Suppose the planter has recently read Montesquieu's *The Spirit of the Laws*, including his critique of slavery. Reading this book makes him look differently at what selling the man would actually mean: he would cause great suffering by separating a father from his wife and children, probably forever.

Howard and Korver treat this not as an answer, but as a prompt for reflection. He must ask what principle that unease is pointing toward and make it explicit in his personal ethical code. The planter is supposed to make what that voice is telling him explicit as a principle in his **personal ethical code**—"the half-dozen principles your inner voice tells you to hold dear" (p. 69). He might articulate a principle such as: **I should not separate families or inflict serious harm without compelling reason.**

That changes the frame and thus decision. "How can I pay my son's tuition?" becomes

May I inflict this harm on this family in order to fulfill my obligation to my son?

That is an important accomplishment. Decision Ethics has prevented him from treating the decision as merely a problem of money. It has made visible something that his original frame concealed.

And some principles can establish what Howard and Korver call **bright lines**: boundaries that are not crossed merely because crossing them produces sufficiently attractive consequences.

The planter might formulate the principle:

I should not destroy another family for the benefit of my own.

If he concludes that this is a bright line, selling the man would not simply receive a very negative score in the decision analysis. It would be removed from the permissible alternatives, and DA would operate on what remains.

Here's the mechanism:

Inner voice → reconsider the frame → formulate/consult principles → identify possible bright lines → determine permissible alternatives → DA

Montesquieu has helped him see what his original frame concealed. Decision Ethics gives him a way to articulate the principle at stake, and reframe the

decision accordingly. But this is an unfamiliar and momentous decision, so he is not confident in his judgement. He wants to know whether he is seeing the situation clearly, so he turns to the person whose moral judgment he trusts most.

C. A New Bright Line

Being a responsible, pious Christian, before making such a momentous decision, the planter decides he needs to consult the person whose moral judgment he trusts most: his minister.

The minister's reaction is surprising. He admonishes the planter for failing to see the other ethical obligation at stake. He is a father with a serious responsibility for his son's future; the enslaved man is, according to the law and dominant custom of their society, property that he may use to meet that responsibility.

The minister formulates a principle:

A father must not sacrifice his child's future when he possesses a lawful means of providing for it.

That principle, too, can function as a bright line. From the minister's perspective, refusing the sale may now look like the ethical failure.

The planter therefore faces a harder problem. Reflection prompted by Montesquieu has produced one principle; consultation with a trusted moral teacher has produced another.

But which principle should govern?

This is now an **evaluation problem**: two principles that the planter can sincerely regard as morally serious point in opposite directions.

Decision Ethics can test the principles for consistency, rationalization, bright-line status, and so forth; but those tests do not themselves constitute a general rule for **ranking two principles that survive them**.

What should determine which principle deserves priority?

4. Why not import another ethical theory?

Decision Ethics gives us substantial help in framing ethical decisions: it asks us to notice ethical unease, identify affected parties, separate ethical questions from legal and prudential ones, and make our principles explicit. The planter's case raises a narrower question: **what enables us to examine assumptions that do not yet appear to us as ethical assumptions at all?** And once competing

principles have survived that examination, **what determines which should govern?**

These problems are connected. The same person who frames the decision must also evaluate the principles that challenge that frame. And that person (us, the agent) has already been shaped by law, religion, family, interest, habit, and history.

We can import another ethical theory to try to resolve this issue, since there are plenty available. Consequentialism, Kantian ethics, and virtue ethics each offer different ways of deciding which consideration should govern. Another ethical theory might give us a standard for deciding the case, and some may also contain resources for examining the judge. My interest here is in a tradition that places that examination near the center of its method.

Howard and Korver, in surveying the world's ethical traditions in their book, briefly mention Yoga, citing “the first stage of the eight stages of yoga” (p. 53). Having taught and practiced Yoga philosophy for twenty years, I think this is **one philosophical resource especially interesting for where we are**. I want to explore that avenue not simply as another ethical code to import into DA, but because it also offers a **discipline for examining the person** who frames the problem and evaluates the principles

5. A contrasting approach: examine the chooser

Yoga here doesn't mean stretching and asanas. It's a school of philosophy with a foundational text, **Patañjali's Yoga Sūtra** from around 400CE, and an ethical theory of its own. Today I'll leave most of the details of that theory out for now and focus on one thing: why it may offer an answer to our two problems. What makes it useful here is that it combines an ethical ideal with a practice of examining the person applying it.

In Shyam Ranganathan's work on the Sutras, Sovereignty is the ideal to be devoted to, and is expressed in two essential traits:

Self-governance: one's judgments and actions are genuinely one's own, rather than simply products of affliction or past conditioning.

In practice, that means remaining alert to the assumptions shaping our decisions, especially when the inner voice tells us that something is wrong. In the planter's case, he would not just ask whether selling the man violates one of his principles. He would ask why selling a person appeared as an alternative in the first place.

Unconservatism: should actively test and act against what one has inherited or previously settled on.

Here the inner voice is a reason not to defend the existing frame, but to investigate it. The planter should actively test the other side: What if ownership does not give me the right to sell him? What if his obligations to his own family matter as much as mine? The more uncomfortable that perspective is, the more important it may be to examine rather than dismiss it.

And the ideal of Sovereignty is not mine in particular. What it expresses, self-governance and unconservatism, is something every person shares an interest in. Devotion to Sovereignty, rather than merely to my own sovereignty, therefore commits me to the agency of the people my decisions affect. So the question becomes not only whether my decision follows my principles, but whether the principles and practices I act on recognize the agency of the people they affect.

That gives us a way back to the *yamas* Howard and Korver mention. The first is **ahimsā**, usually translated as non-harm. In Ranganathan's account, however, it is more active: the disruption of harm. And harm matters because it undermines another person's ability to govern their own life. To coerce, exploit, or dominate another person is therefore not merely to cause suffering; it attacks, in someone else, the very thing the practice is devoted to.

If we evaluate the case through this commitment to Sovereignty and ahimsā, what counts as ethically decisive changes. The issue is not only that selling the man will cause suffering, but that slavery itself is a practice of domination: the planter claims authority over another person's movement, labor, family, and future. From this perspective, the sale is not simply one harmful consequence to weigh against his duty to his son. It continues and intensifies a relationship that denies the enslaved man the very agency Sovereignty asks us to recognize. The ethical task is therefore not merely to minimize the harm of the sale, but to question and, where possible, disrupt the practice that makes the sale possible at all.

6. Conclusion

So what has happened in this case?

Decision Ethics did a great deal of important work. It prevented an ethical question from being treated as merely a financial one. The inner voice prompted reconsideration of the frame; principles were made explicit; and bright lines

prevented ethics from becoming just another consequence to trade off against tuition, debt, or family ambition.

We reached a difficulty only when two apparently serious principles pointed in opposite directions, and when the assumptions behind those principles themselves became part of the question. At that point, the tools we had used to clarify and test those principles did not by themselves determine which should govern.

Yoga gave us one way to continue the inquiry. Self-governance directed attention to what was shaping the planter's judgment; unconservatism required him to challenge assumptions he had inherited or settled on; and ahimsā brought the agency of the enslaved man into the evaluation itself. The ethical task was no longer merely to minimize the harm caused by selling him, but to question the practice that made selling another person seem like a permissible alternative at all.

And that brings us back to Decision Analysis. On this account, selling the man is no longer in the permissible set, the planter still has a difficult decision: borrow more, sell land, cut expenses, or reconsider his plans for his son. Decision Analysis can now do what it does well, help him reason carefully among those alternatives under uncertainty.

So the point is not that Yoga replaces Decision Ethics. Decision Ethics gives us a powerful discipline for acting consistently with our ethical commitments. The Yoga perspective offered one way to continue at a particular point where the commitments and the standpoint from which we formed them had themselves become uncertain. Having reopened that question, we can return to Decision Analysis with a better frame.

Appendix A: Turning the Ethical Lens on Decision Analysis

Ronald Howard explicitly describes Decision Analysis as “amoral”: it helps an agent make a rational decision given their objectives, beliefs, and preferences, without determining what those objectives ought morally to be. But that claim itself may have embedded ethical assumptions:

1. What counts as rational?

DA gives us powerful standards of consistency: beliefs should obey probability, preferences should be ordered coherently, and choices should follow from them.

- But is consistency the whole of rationality?
- Could someone be perfectly consistent while pursuing foolish, unjust, or destructive ends?
- What kinds of practical wisdom might fall outside formal rationality?

2. Does what cannot be measured disappear?

DA works by making the relevant features of a decision explicit enough to compare.

- What happens to values that are difficult to quantify: dignity, loyalty, sacredness, identity, relationship?
- Does pressure to measure them distort them, or make less measurable considerations easier to neglect?
- “Not in the model” can quietly become “not important.”

3. Does quantification create false precision?

Probabilities and utilities let us reason rigorously under uncertainty.

- But assigning a number can make a highly uncertain judgment appear more objective than it is.
- Mathematical precision in the calculation does not necessarily imply precision in the assumptions.
- Could the authority of the model discourage us from questioning weak inputs?

Appendix B: Our 1785?

The Virginia case may have seemed easy for us, but are there some modern examples which may be similarly difficult to see from within?

Eating meat is one possible example. The decision is often framed as a matter of taste, nutrition, price, convenience, or tradition: *What should I have for dinner?* Yet that frame already assumes that animals may appropriately be bred, confined, killed, and turned into products for human use. As with the planter, legality and widespread social acceptance do not settle the ethical question; they may instead help keep a deeper question outside the frame.

The parallel need not tell us what conclusion to reach. It simply gives us a contemporary case on which to use the methods we have discussed. What does our inner voice notice? What principles would we make explicit? What

assumptions have entered the frame as facts rather than ethical claims? Whose interests or agency disappear from the description of the decision?

And, most importantly, what practices that seem morally ordinary to us might look very different to someone looking back from 250 years in the future?

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